

Common errors and how to fix them

Day 1 - Introduction to Data Analysis with R

Selina Baldauf

Freie Universität Berlin - Theoretical Ecology

October 7, 2026

Errors are how you learn

When learning a programming language, you will run into errors all the time. That's completely normal and it's how programming works!

debugging



1.
I got this.



2.
Huh. Really
thought that
was it.



3.
(...)



8.
A NEW HOPE!



4.
Fine. Restarting.



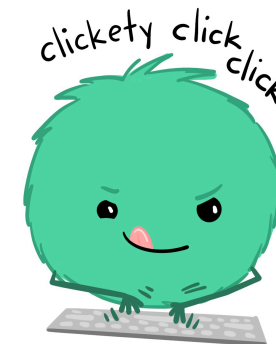
5.
OH WTF.



6..
Zombie
meltdown



7.



9.
[insert awesome
theme song]



10.
I ♥ CODING!

@allison_horst

Artwork by Allison Horst

First things first: Set R to English

- The R language setting follows your operating system language by default
- Errors might not be in English - hard to find help online

Fix: Change the R language setting to English

```
# For the current session  
Sys.setLanguage("en")
```

Add it to your .Renviron

The `.Renviron` file is read automatically every time you start R.

Open the file with:

```
# install the usethis package  
# install.packages("usethis")  
# Open the .Renviron file in RStudio  
usethis::edit_r_environ()
```

and add the line `LANGUAGE=en` to the file. Save it and restart R.

Most common errors for beginners

and how to deal with them

Console prints +

R is not running code anymore and the console only prints +



The screenshot shows an R console window with the following content:

```
122:1 (Top Level)   
in apply(marginc, ZL, cumsum) : NAS introduced by coercion  
> barplot(biodata$richness, names.arg=c("Beetle",  
+ "Bird",  
+ "Butterfly",  
+ "Dragonfly",  
+ "Fl.Plants",  
+ "Fungus",  
+ "Hymenopteran",  
+ "Lichen",  
+ "Liverwort",  
+ "Mammal",  
+ "Mollusc"),  
+ xlab="Taxa", ylab="Number of species", ylim=c(0,600), cex.axis=1.5, cex.lab=1.5
```

How to fix it

- Go to the console and hit **Escape**. Then you should see the **>** sign instead of **+** again.
- Likely you forgot to close a bracket or a quote somewhere. Go to your script and check where this happened (look for  next to line numbers)

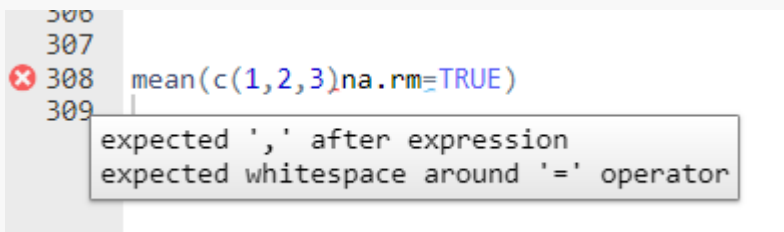
Syntax errors

Example

```
mean(c(1, 2, 3)na.rm = TRUE)
#> Error in parse(text = input): <text>:1:16: unexpected symbol
#> 1: mean(c(1, 2, 3)na.rm
#>                        ^
```

How to fix

- Look for missing commas, misspelled arguments, unclosed brackets, ...
- Read the error message, it often points you to where the problem is
- The RStudio syntax checker warns you **before** you run code with syntax errors
 - Look for  next to line numbers in your script



Error: object not found

Example

```
variable_A  
#> Error:  
#> ! object 'variable_A' not found
```

How to fix

- You are trying to access an object that does not exist. Common reasons:
 - Typo in the variable name (e.g. you created `variableA` but typed `variable_A`)
 - You forgot to run the line of code that creates the variable
 - You forgot to put quotes around a string: `print(hello)` looks for a **variable** named `hello`, but you wanted `print("hello")`

Package problems

Could not find function

```
read_csv("data/penguins.csv")  
#> Error in `read_csv()`:  
#> ! could not find function "read_csv"
```

- You forgot to **load the package**:
`library(tidyverse)`
- You have a **typo** in the function name
(e.g. `lenght()` instead of `length()`)

Package not found

```
library(thispackagedoesntexist)  
#> Error in `library()`:  
#> ! there is no package called 'thispackagedoesntexist'
```

- The package is **not installed**:
`install.packages("thispackagedoesntexist")`
- You have a **typo** in the package name

Remember for packages: **install once**, but **load every time** you start R

File not found

When reading data, you might see errors like:

```
readr::read_csv("data/penguins.csv")  
#> Error:  
#> ! 'data/penguins.csv' does not exist in current working directory:  
#> 'C:/Users/Selina/Documents/Repos/Teaching/intro-r-data-analysis/sessions/slides'.
```

How to fix

- Check that you are in the **correct RStudio project** (look at the top right corner of RStudio)
- Check the **file name**: is it spelled exactly right?
- Check the **folder path**: is the file actually in the **data/** folder?

Build your path with auto-completion

When you start typing a path in RStudio, you can use auto-completion to avoid typos. Start with `"` and then hit tab to see suggestions for files and folders in your project.

Not all red text is an error

- **Errors:** something went wrong and your code did not run
- **Warnings:** your code still ran, but R tells you something might be wrong (e.g. **NA** values in your data)
 - Make sure to **read and understand** warnings
 - Only ignore them if you know that's okay
- **Messages:** just information, e.g. when you load the tidyverse

What to do when you're stuck

- Read the error message
- Check your data: use `summary()` or `View()` to see if your data looks the way you expect
- Read the function help with `?function_name`
- Restart R and run your script from the top (Session > Restart R in RStudio)
- Search online or ask AI

Make sure to **save your scripts regularly**. Sometimes R crashes and you have to start a new R session.